Preface

Kashmir has been in the news, for various reasons, for the past three decades or more. Much has been written about its various dimensions, and how it was the cause of wars between India and Pakistan since 1947. However, there are fewer studies on the events that led to Kashmir becoming such a contentious issue between India and Pakistan, especially over the century preceding the Partition (from 1846 to 1947). There is, thus, the need for a much deeper understanding of the subject. It was with this intent in mind that I suggested to my co-author Iqbal Malhotra and our publishers, especially Nitin Valecha of Bloomsbury, that a book like this one needs to be published. And this led us to this book that you now hold in your hands.

My own understanding of Kashmir began during my postgraduate studies in the UK, when I chose to write my MPhil dissertation at Cambridge University on low-intensity conflicts in India. On leaving the army prematurely, I was awarded a fellowship from *The Times of India* and wrote my earlier work titled *Wars and No Peace Over Kashmir*. For both these projects, I did a fair amount of research and travelled to Jammu and the Kashmir Valley, in the mid-1990s, and met people from all sections of the society. The current insurgency was in its nascent stages and there were many seminars debating the Kashmir issue. But, there was no single narrative that would be acceptable across India. Unlike Indians, who are at the helm of these debates, the Pakistanis always asserted that Kashmir should be theirs and that India had outmanoeuvred them at the Partition.

Obviously, it wasn’t that simple as my research and reading over the past 25 years have led me to believe. Besides, I have participated in hundreds of prime-time television debates where I have been pitted against Pakistanis, who have a selective understanding of the post-independence history of the region. Many of their perspectives are coloured by their loyalty to their deep state and they are often unaware of actual facts. Among the Kashmiris I have engaged with, there is now an obsession for